basement parking. The Tatas, who own AI, will put up Rs 53 crore, the state has allocated Rs 34.65 crore. Health minister Praful Pansheriya announced the plan with matter-of-factness.

DEMAND FOR MEMORIAL

The families are not acquiescing. "For us, this space is not merely land. It is a site connected to loss.... We respectfully but firmly request that (it) be preserved as a memorial space," they wrote to the state. The idea has legacy. Gujarat has a memorial in Kutch for the 185 schoolkids killed in the 2001 quake. Hiroshima has kept alive a UNESCO World Heritage Site. New York, the world's most expensive city, tiptoes around the shadow of the Twin Towers.

Slick infrastructure growing over their memory is not the kind of closure the Flight 171 kin seek. A hostel could be more 'useful', they concede, but ask: couldn't such a utilitarian turn at least wait till the probe is closed, the cause nailed, the onus fixed?

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau's final report is due on June 12. The key question: why did both engine fuel control switches go from 'RUN' to 'CUTOFF' within a second of each other? The cockpit voice recorder has one pilot ask why they had moved, the other says he hadn't touched them. Three theories are in play: chance flip by pilot, electrical fault, mechanical defect. The last trail—which would bring liabilities—is no way closed. A US Federal Aviation Administration bulletin flagged a design vulnerability in 2018. In February, an AI 787-8 saw its left engine fuel switch move on its own from RUN to CUTOFF twice on the Heathrow tarmac.

Right after, AI began presenting the kin with a final compensation offer—with an indemnity document. It asks them to "irrevocably and forever release" any right to sue or make claims against AI, Boeing, component makers, aviation operators and state entities across every global jurisdiction. An extra payout—from a few lakhs, up to Rs 3 crore—is on offer. Says Abbas Ali Padaria, son of deceased Maryam Padariya, who was offered Rs 10 lakh: "It doesn't feel right to accept it before the final investigation report. We want to know what happened."

"Our recommendation to families is not to sign the offer in its current form," says Chuck Chionuma, principal attorney, Chionuma Law. "It asks them to release all possible responsible parties before fault has even been determined." What if, say, a component maker is named? Four families sued Boeing and switch maker Honeywell in Delaware, a case said to be retracted. Sign, as "60 of the 74 injured" reportedly have, and you forfeit all such legal rights. Hostel gardener Ajay Parmar needed to. "My wife left me. I can barely work with my burns. My life's ruined," he says. The void for the bereaved is deeper. ■

Takeaways

- Gujarat plans to build spiffy new hostel at crash site; kin seek memorial
- Offering up to Rs 3 crore, AI asks kin to sign away all future legal claims
- Signees grant indemnity to AI, Boeing, other parties; 120 families refuse

MAHARASHTRA

A Harvest of Tears Stalks Onion County

War, weather and a wholly self-made export muddle combine to bring ruin to a vast belt of small farmers

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IT MAY BE INFLATING PRICES ALL AROUND, but the West Asia crisis has brought tears to the eyes of Maharashtra's onion farmers for the opposite reason. There's a glut in the local market. The high-volume, low-cost commodity gets exported mostly by ships, so emergency surcharges have choked the sealanes to the massive Gulf market. Overland, Bangladesh's protectionist policies block another destination. Adding to the pain of fickle export policies, unseasonal rains amidst a superhot summer have spoilt crop quality. Net effect: farmers in the onion belt around Nashik are getting as low as Re 1 per kg.

So that tragic sight is at hand again: farmers dumping their unsold harvest outside mandis. Those who manage to offload their crop are forced to sell for Rs 100-200 per quintal (100 kg)—far below breakeven, given their rising input costs. This is playing out across the vast onion-cultivating belt of north and western Maharashtra. Nashik district is its core, with 22 wholesale markets, including Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMC) outlets and private entities. But layers of

Takeaways

- Export squeeze creates glut, heat and rain ruin crop quality
- Result: farmers getting a rupee for what cost them Rs 22 to grow